The Baby Moon

40 Days of Postpartum Nourishment

A guide to reclaiming wisdom, rest, and nourishment after birth · My Instant Midwife

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How to Use This Guide

This guide is written for you — the person who has just grown, birthed, and delivered a human being into the world. It is also for your partner, your mother, your sister, your best friend — anyone who wants to support you well in the weeks that follow birth.

It can be read during pregnancy as preparation, or picked up in the days and weeks after your baby arrives. There are no rules. You don't have to read it in order. Go to what you need.

This is not a medical document. It is a guide to an old way of doing things — a way that most of the world still practices, and that Western culture largely abandoned without replacing it with anything better. We are simply inviting you to reclaim it.

> **A note on language**
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> *Throughout this guide we use the word 'mother' and 'she' for ease of reading. We acknowledge that not everyone who gives birth identifies this way — please take what is useful and leave what doesn't fit.*
>
> *Reference: Heng Ou, Amely Greeven & Marisa Belger. The First 40 Days: The Essential Art of Nourishing the New Mother (2016). Some of the philosophy in this guide draws on the wisdom of that book.*

Chapter 1 — What Is the Baby Moon?

"After birth, a woman's body is like a freshly opened flower. It is beautiful and vulnerable at the same time." — Traditional postpartum wisdom

A short season worth everything

The baby moon is the 40 days after birth. It is a short season in your life — roughly six weeks — that deserves to be treated differently from every other period you have known. It is a time to retreat from the world, devote yourself to your baby, and allow yourself to be held, fed, and cared for while your body heals.

This is not laziness. It is not indulgence. It is ancient, cross-cultural wisdom that has been practised by women in China, India, Mexico, the Middle East, and across Africa for thousands of years. In these traditions, the 40 days after birth are considered sacred — a threshold between who you were and who you are becoming.

In China it is called zuo yuezi — doing the month. In Mexico it is la cuarentena. In India, it is the confinement period. The names differ. The wisdom is the same: a new mother needs extraordinary care, not extraordinary demands.

What this time is for

The baby moon is three things simultaneously.

It is physical healing.

Birth — however it happened — is a major physiological event. Your uterus is contracting back to its pre-pregnancy size. Your perineum may be healing from tears or sutures. Your hormones are in a state of dramatic flux. Your blood volume, which increased by 50% during pregnancy, is recalibrating. Your body has done something extraordinary and it needs time to recover from it.

It is relational building.

These 40 days are when you meet your baby. Not just in the practical sense — but in the deep, cellular sense of learning each other. Your baby is learning your smell, your voice, your heartbeat. You are learning their cues, their rhythms, their face. Skin-to-skin, feeding, rest, and uninterrupted closeness are the foundations of attachment — and they need space and quiet to grow.

It is spiritual transition.

Becoming a mother is one of the most significant identity transitions a human being can make. Psychologists call it matrescence — a developmental shift as profound as adolescence. The person you are after birth is not the same person you were before. The baby moon is the time for that transition to happen gently, with support, rather than being immediately overridden by the demands of normal life.

Why Western culture has largely abandoned this

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Somewhere along the way, Western culture decided that the fastest return to 'normal' after birth was the goal. New mothers are praised for being back at the gym at six weeks. Praised for managing visitors. Praised for appearing to cope.

This is not wisdom. It is a cultural failure.

The result is a generation of mothers who are depleted, disconnected, and silently struggling. Postnatal depression rates are rising. Relationship breakdowns in the first year after birth are among the highest of any life stage. Chronic fatigue and hormonal imbalance affect a significant proportion of new mothers years after their children are born.

None of this is inevitable. Most of it is the result of asking too much of women who have just been through the most demanding experience of their lives — without adequate rest, nourishment, or support.

We can do better. And we can start by reclaiming 40 days.

You deserve these 40 days

Read that sentence again. You deserve these 40 days. Not as a reward. Not if you've earned them. Not if everything is going well. You deserve them because you are a human being who has just done something extraordinary, and extraordinary things require extraordinary recovery.

The world will still be there at 40 days. Your career will still be there. Your social obligations will still be there. The only thing that cannot be recovered is time — the time with your newborn, in this brief, impossibly tender season.

This guide is about making the most of it.

CHAPTER RECAP

- The baby moon is the 40 days after birth — a period practised across cultures globally for thousands of years
- This time is simultaneously physical healing, relational building, and spiritual transition
- Western culture largely abandoned this wisdom — and the consequences are visible in postnatal depletion, depression, and disconnection
- Retreating, resting, and accepting nourishment and care during this time is not weakness — it is ancient, evidence-aligned wisdom
- You deserve these 40 days. Not as a luxury. As a necessity.

📓 Chapter 1 Reflection

What does the phrase 'baby moon' bring up for you? Does it feel possible? What feels like a barrier?

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What did your own mother do in the weeks after giving birth? What do you know about that time?

What would 40 days of being truly looked after look like for you? Write it without editing yourself.

✏️ **YOUR PREPARATION TASK**

Preparation task — read before birth:

1. Share this chapter with your partner or support person. Ask them to read it. Then have a conversation about what the baby moon could look like for your family.
2. Write a list of five people who you trust to support you in the first 40 days. Not to visit — to help. We'll come back to this list.
3. Consider when you want to share the news of your birth. Setting a boundary around who is told and when, before the baby arrives, removes a significant mental load in the early days.

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Chapter 2 — The Five Insights: Reclaiming Ancient Wisdom

In her book The First 40 Days, Heng Ou — a practitioner of Chinese postpartum wisdom — describes five insights that form the foundation of traditional postpartum care. They are simple. They are old. And they are more relevant today than ever. This chapter explores each one honestly, without romanticising the past, and considers how they apply to modern life.

Insight 1 — Retreat

In many traditional cultures, the postpartum period was called the confinement period. That word has uncomfortable connotations today — and rightly so. But the intention behind it was not restriction. It was protection.

After birth, a new mother's immune system is temporarily compromised. Sleep deprivation, hormonal upheaval, blood loss, and healing wounds all reduce the body's ability to fight infection. Perineal sutures, open lochia, engorged breasts, and a healing uterus all represent potential entry points for bacteria. Historically, keeping a new mother warm and secluded was not about controlling her — it was about keeping her well.

Today, retreat looks different. It does not mean locking the doors. It means consciously choosing to stay home for at least the first two weeks. It means not attending family gatherings or social events. It means not hosting visitors who need entertaining. It means saying no, without explanation or apology, to anything that requires you to perform.

> **Consider this**
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> *Research consistently shows that the risk of postpartum infection, including endometritis, mastitis, and wound infection, is highest in the first two weeks. These are not rare complications — they are common consequences of a body that is healing from a major event while simultaneously being exposed to the demands of social life.*
>
> *Rest and retreat are the cheapest, most effective, and most underused interventions available to a new mother.*

Insight 2 — Warmth

Traditional postpartum wisdom across cultures — Chinese, Ayurvedic, Mexican — emphasises warmth above almost everything else. The reasoning is physiological: birth involves significant blood loss. Even a straightforward vaginal birth results in 200–500ml of blood loss. A caesarean section can involve considerably more.

Blood carries warmth. When significant blood volume is lost, many women feel cold — not just physically, but in a deeper sense of depletion. Traditional postpartum cultures respond to this by warming the body from the inside out. Warm foods, warming spices, warm teas, and warm baths all serve to replenish what was lost and restore vitality.

In Chinese tradition, cold foods and cold drinks are avoided entirely in the postpartum period — even in summer. The reasoning: a depleted body needs warmth to heal, and cold contracts and tightens where warmth opens and restores.

This doesn't mean you can't have a glass of cold water. It means that consciously choosing

warming foods and drinks during this time supports your body's recovery in a way that cold, raw, or processed foods simply don't.

Warming foods and herbs for the postpartum period:

- Bone broth — mineral-rich, warming, deeply nourishing, and easy to sip between feeds
- Root vegetables — sweet potato, carrot, parsnip, beetroot — grounding and iron-rich
- Warming spices — ginger, turmeric, cinnamon, cardamom — anti-inflammatory and circulation-supporting
- Dark leafy greens — spinach, kale — iron and folate-rich for blood replenishment
- Oats — warming, galactagogue (supports milk supply), grounding
- Red meat and lentils — iron and protein for blood building and tissue repair

> **Research note**
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> *Iron deficiency affects up to 50% of women in the postpartum period (Milman, 2011). Symptoms include fatigue, low mood, poor concentration, and reduced milk supply. Replenishing iron through food in the first weeks is one of the most impactful nutritional interventions for new mothers. Warming, iron-rich foods are not just comforting — they are clinically relevant.*

Insight 3 — Support

This insight is the one most modern Western mothers find hardest. Not because they don't need support — they do, desperately — but because accepting it requires dismantling the narrative that independence is strength and needing help is weakness.

It is not. Needing help after birth is not weakness. It is a biological reality. Humans are not designed to mother alone. Across human history and across cultures, new mothers have been supported by a community of women — mothers, sisters, aunts, neighbours — who cooked, cleaned, held the baby, cared for older children, and created a circle of care around the person who had just given birth.

The nuclear family — two adults, alone, managing a newborn — is historically and anthropologically unusual. It is also, for many families, genuinely unsustainable in the early weeks.

Accepting support looks like:

- Saying yes when someone asks if they can bring food
- Asking your mother or mother-in-law to take the older children for a day
- Letting someone else do the laundry without supervising how they do it
- Asking your partner to manage all visitor requests and family communications
- Hiring a postpartum doula if your budget allows
- Being honest with people about what you need rather than saying you're fine

> **For partners and support people**
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> *Your role in the baby moon is not to watch and admire. It is to cook, clean, protect the mother's rest, manage the outside world, and absorb every domestic task so that she can focus entirely on feeding, healing, and meeting her baby. This is the most important job you will do in these 40 days. Take it seriously.*

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Insight 4 — Rest

This is the one everyone knows is important and almost no one actually does. Not because they don't want to — but because our social norms make rest feel like failure.

A new mother who is resting when visitors arrive looks lazy. A new mother who is resting when the house is messy looks like she isn't coping. A new mother who says she is too tired to come to family dinner looks difficult. These are the stories we tell. They are wrong.

Rest is not laziness. Rest is a clinical imperative. Sleep deprivation at the level experienced by new parents in the early weeks impairs cognitive function, emotional regulation, immune response, and physical healing — all of which directly affects not just the mother but the baby she is caring for.

The research is unambiguous. A 2019 study in the Journal of Sleep Research found that sleep fragmentation — even with adequate total sleep hours — significantly elevated inflammatory markers and reduced immune function. This is the sleep pattern of a new mother. Her immune system is genuinely compromised by the sleep she is not getting. Rest, wherever it can be found, is a genuine intervention.

Rest in the baby moon looks like:

- Sleeping when the baby sleeps — even if this is only 20 minutes at a time
- Lying down even when you can't sleep — the body still rests
- Not hosting visitors for the first two weeks unless they come to serve, not be served
- Not cleaning, cooking, managing social media, or responding to messages during rest windows
- Protecting a minimum of one unbroken sleep window per 24 hours — even if this requires agreement with your partner about night feeds

> **Permission slip**
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> *You are allowed to rest. You do not need to earn it. You do not need to justify it. You do not need to explain it to anyone. Growing a baby took nine months. Birthing them took everything you had. Resting now is not optional — it is how you heal.*

Insight 5 — Ritual

Ritual is the insight that feels most foreign to modern Western culture — and the one that, for many women, becomes the most meaningful.

Across traditional postpartum cultures, physical rituals were performed on and for the new mother. Postpartum abdominal massage. Warm oil treatments for the body and scalp. Foot massage. Hair brushing. Body wrapping. These were not spa treatments. They were acts of care — performed by other women, for a woman who had just been through one of the most physically demanding experiences of her life.

The message these rituals conveyed was simple: your body matters. You matter. You are seen, honoured, and cared for.

In a culture where new mothers are often invisible — celebrated for producing a baby, then largely overlooked — this message is not trivial. It is profoundly healing.

Ritual in the modern baby moon might include:

- A daily warm bath with essential oils while someone else holds the baby
- Postpartum abdominal massage with warm oil — supporting uterine involution and reducing bloating

- A foot massage in the evening — activating the parasympathetic nervous system and supporting sleep
- Having your hair washed and brushed — a deeply soothing act of care that many mothers report as unexpectedly emotional
- A closing the bones ceremony — explored in depth in Chapter 6
- Yoni steaming — explored in depth in Chapter 6

These rituals do not require a therapist or a practitioner. They require another person, some warm oil, and the willingness to receive care. Ask for them. You deserve them.

CHAPTER RECAP

- Insight 1 — Retreat: protect your home as a healing space. Say no without apology for at least the first two weeks.
- Insight 2 — Warmth: replenish blood loss and iron with warming foods, root vegetables, broths, and warming spices. Cold, raw, and processed foods can wait.
- Insight 3 — Support: accept every offer of help. Ask for specific things. You are not designed to do this alone and you do not have to.
- Insight 4 — Rest: rest is a clinical imperative. Sleep deprivation impairs healing, immunity, and mental health. Protect your rest windows fiercely.
- Insight 5 — Ritual: physical acts of care — massage, baths, hair brushing — communicate that you matter. Ask for them. Receive them.

📓 Chapter 2 Reflection

Which of the five insights feels hardest for you to embrace? What story are you telling yourself about it?

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Who in your life could perform acts of ritual care for you — massage, hair brushing, foot care? Have you told them this is what you need?

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What does your partner or support person think about the idea of retreat and rest? Are they aligned with you? If not, what conversation needs to happen?

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✏️ YOUR PREPARATION TASK

Preparation task:

4. Write your baby moon vision statement — a short paragraph describing what you want your first 40 days to look and feel like. Share it with your partner.
5. Have a specific conversation with your partner about the five insights. Which ones do they find easy to support? Which feel challenging? Where do you need to get aligned before the baby arrives?
6. Decide on your visitor policy and write it down: who, when, for how long, and what they are expected to bring or do. Your partner is in charge of communicating this to family and friends.

Chapter 3 — Nourishing Your Body After Birth

We spend a great deal of time and energy talking about what to eat during pregnancy. What to eat after birth — when your body is healing, your hormones are in freefall, and you are feeding a baby on what your own body produces — is discussed far less.

This is a significant gap. Because what you eat in the first 40 days has a direct impact on your energy, your mood, your milk supply, your hormonal recovery, your wound healing, and your ability to be present for your baby. Food is not just nourishment. In the postpartum period, it is medicine.

We are also going to be completely honest about the reality of eating with a newborn. You are not going to be preparing elaborate meals. You are not going to have the mental bandwidth to follow complex recipes. The food you eat in these 40 days needs to be simple, warming, nourishing, and ideally prepared by someone else. This chapter will tell you exactly what to eat and why — and give you the tools to stock your kitchen before your baby arrives.

What your body needs and why

Iron — to replenish what was lost in birth

Blood loss in birth — even a straightforward one — is significant. Iron deficiency postpartum is extremely common, affecting up to 50% of new mothers, and its symptoms — fatigue, low mood, difficulty concentrating, poor milk supply — are often attributed to 'just being tired' rather than a treatable nutritional deficiency.

Iron-rich foods: red meat, liver (in moderation), dark leafy greens (spinach, kale), lentils, beans, fortified cereals, tofu, pumpkin seeds. Pair with Vitamin C to maximise absorption. Avoid tea or coffee around iron-rich meals as they inhibit absorption.

Omega-3 fatty acids — for mental health and brain recovery

DHA (a type of Omega-3) is one of the most important nutrients for postnatal mental health. The brain is 60% fat — and DHA is heavily concentrated in the prefrontal cortex, the part of the brain most affected by postpartum depression. During pregnancy, your baby draws heavily on your DHA stores. If these are not replenished, the result can be low mood, brain fog, and emotional fragility.

Omega-3 sources: oily fish (salmon, sardines, mackerel — 2-3 times a week), walnuts, flaxseeds, chia seeds, hemp seeds. A postnatal DHA supplement is worth considering if oily fish is not a regular feature of your diet.

> **Research note**
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> *A 2018 meta-analysis in the Journal of Affective Disorders found that Omega-3 supplementation was associated with significant reductions in postpartum depression symptoms. DHA depletion during pregnancy and early breastfeeding is well-documented and is a modifiable risk factor for postnatal mood disorders.*

Protein — for tissue repair and sustained energy

Every tissue in your body — your uterus, your perineum, your abdominal muscles — is rebuilding itself after birth. Protein provides the amino acids needed for this repair. It also

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sustains energy levels and supports the immune system.

Protein sources: eggs, lean meat, fish, pulses, tofu, nuts, Greek yogurt, cheese. Aim for a protein source at every meal and snack. Eggs in particular are a postpartum superfood — quick, versatile, and nutrient-dense.

Calcium and Vitamin D — for bone health and mood

Breastfeeding draws significantly on your calcium reserves. Vitamin D deficiency is extremely common, particularly in the UK, and is directly linked to low mood, fatigue, and compromised immune function. The NHS recommends 10mcg daily throughout breastfeeding.

Calcium sources: dairy, fortified plant milks, dark leafy greens, almonds, tahini. Vitamin D: sunlight (15 minutes on skin daily when possible), oily fish, eggs, fortified foods, supplement.

Zinc — for immune function and wound healing

Zinc is often overlooked in postpartum nutrition, but it is critical for wound healing (perineal tears, caesarean incisions), immune function, and hormonal balance. Breastfeeding increases zinc requirements significantly.

Zinc sources: meat, shellfish, pumpkin seeds, legumes, nuts, dairy.

Folate and B vitamins — for energy and mood

The B vitamin family — particularly B12, B6, and folate — are essential for energy metabolism, red blood cell production, and the synthesis of serotonin and dopamine. Depletion of B vitamins is common after birth and contributes to the fatigue and low mood of the early postpartum period.

Sources: leafy greens, eggs, meat, fortified cereals, sunflower seeds, chickpeas.

Foods that support milk supply

For breastfeeding mothers, milk supply is both precious and anxiety-inducing. While the most important factors in milk supply are feeding frequency and effective latch, certain foods — called galactagogues — are traditionally associated with supporting supply. The evidence for most is anecdotal rather than clinical, but they are nutritious regardless.

Galactagogue foods:

- Oats — porridge, overnight oats, oat biscuits. The most widely reported galactagogue food.
- Fenugreek — a traditional galactagogue herb, available as seeds or tea. Note: avoid in large quantities if you have thyroid issues.
- Brewer's yeast — add to smoothies or baked goods. Rich in B vitamins and iron.
- Fennel seeds — warming, digestive, and traditionally milk-supporting. Lovely as a tea.
- Dark leafy greens — spinach, kale, and moringa are all nutritionally dense and traditionally associated with milk production.
- Nuts and seeds — almonds, flaxseeds, and sesame seeds are particularly valued.
- Bone broth — deeply nourishing, warm, and easy to sip throughout the day.

Hydration is also critical for milk supply. A breastfeeding mother needs an additional 400–500ml of fluid per day above normal requirements. Keep a large water bottle or warm herbal tea accessible at all times.

Foods and hormonal recovery

The hormonal landscape after birth is one of the most dramatic in human biology. Oestrogen and progesterone — which were at their highest levels ever during pregnancy — drop sharply within 24–48 hours of birth. This hormonal crash is directly responsible for the baby blues, and for many women, the beginning of postpartum depression.

Certain foods support the liver's ability to metabolise and clear these hormones efficiently, and others support the gradual rebalancing of the endocrine system.

- Cruciferous vegetables (broccoli, cauliflower, Brussels sprouts) — support oestrogen metabolism
- Flaxseeds — contain lignans that gently support hormonal balance
- Turmeric — anti-inflammatory and supports liver function
- Magnesium-rich foods (dark chocolate, almonds, spinach, avocado) — magnesium is depleted by stress and supports cortisol regulation, sleep quality, and mood
- Probiotic foods (live yogurt, kefir, sauerkraut) — gut health and hormonal health are deeply interconnected

CHAPTER RECAP

- Iron: replenish blood loss with red meat, dark leafy greens, lentils, and Vitamin C to support absorption
- Omega-3s: critical for postnatal mental health — oily fish, walnuts, flaxseeds, and consider a DHA supplement
- Protein: for tissue repair and sustained energy — eggs, meat, pulses, nuts at every meal
- Galactagogues: oats, fennel, brewer's yeast, almonds, bone broth, and dark leafy greens support milk supply
- Hormonal recovery: cruciferous vegetables, flaxseeds, turmeric, magnesium, and probiotic foods support the endocrine system
- Hydration: additional 400–500ml per day for breastfeeding mothers — warm herbal teas count

📓 Chapter 3 Reflection

Are you currently deficient in iron? Have you had your levels checked? What iron-rich foods could you increase in your diet now, before birth?

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Does your current diet include regular Omega-3 sources? If not, what could you add or supplement?

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Who will prepare your meals in the first two weeks after birth? Have you had this conversation with them?

✏️ **YOUR PREPARATION TASK**

Preparation task — stock your kitchen:

7. This week, make a batch of bone broth and freeze it in portions. It will be the most nourishing thing you can have in the first week.
8. Stock your pantry with the postpartum essentials: oats, lentils, canned fish, nut butters, frozen spinach, good quality stock, eggs, and warming spices.
9. Write a shopping list for the first two weeks postpartum and give it to someone who will shop for you. Make it specific.
10. Consider a postnatal supplement if you are not already taking one — look for one containing iron, B12, DHA, Vitamin D, and zinc.

Chapter 4 — Preparing Your Baby Moon Kitchen

The most practical act of preparation you can do before your baby arrives is stock your freezer. Not with convenience food. With real, nourishing, homemade food that can be reheated in minutes and eaten one-handed while a baby is attached to you.

The golden rule of postpartum eating: everything should be warm, soft, one-handed where possible, and prepared by someone else. Soup. Stews. Bone broth. Smoothies. Oat-based snacks. These are not compromise foods. They are the most nourishing, most efficient forms of nutrition available to a new mother.

This chapter gives you five meal ideas, five tea recipes, and a framework for stocking your kitchen. Take it shopping with you.

Five nourishing postpartum meals to batch cook and freeze

1. Golden Bone Broth

Why: Rich in collagen, minerals, glycine, and easily absorbed nutrients. Collagen supports wound healing, joint repair, and gut lining integrity — all of which are directly relevant to postpartum recovery. Bone broth is the single most nourishing thing you can make ahead.

How: Simmer chicken or beef bones (ideally with a splash of apple cider vinegar to draw out the minerals) for 12–24 hours with an onion, carrots, celery, bay leaves, peppercorns, and a few sprigs of rosemary. Strain, cool, and freeze in 300ml portions. Reheat and sip from a mug between feeds.

- Iron, calcium, magnesium, phosphorus, collagen
- Supports wound healing, joint health, gut repair
- Warming and deeply nourishing — ready in minutes from frozen

2. Red Lentil and Sweet Potato Soup with Ginger and Turmeric

Why: Red lentils are one of the best plant-based iron sources and cook quickly. Sweet potato provides beta-carotene (Vitamin A precursor), potassium, and complex carbohydrates for sustained energy. Ginger and turmeric are anti-inflammatory and warming — exactly what a postpartum body needs.

How: Fry onion and garlic in olive oil. Add 2 tsp each of ground ginger and turmeric (add fresh ginger if you have it), plus 1 tsp cumin. Add 300g red lentils, 2 medium sweet potatoes (cubed), 1.5 litres of stock. Simmer 25 minutes until soft. Blend. Freeze in portions. Reheat and top with a swirl of cream or coconut milk.

- Iron, beta-carotene, anti-inflammatory compounds
- Blood sugar stabilising, warming, hormone-supportive
- Easily eaten one-handed from a mug or bowl

3. Slow-Cooked Lamb and Root Vegetable Stew

Why: Lamb is one of the richest sources of haem iron (the most bioavailable form), B12, and zinc. Root vegetables — parsnip, carrot, turnip — are grounding, warming, and deeply nourishing. Slow cooking makes the meat tender enough to eat without much effort.

How: Brown diced lamb in a casserole dish. Add chopped onion, garlic, 2 carrots, 2 parsnips,

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2 turnips, 1 tin of tomatoes, 500ml bone broth or stock, rosemary, and thyme. Cook at 160°C for 3 hours (or in a slow cooker for 8 hours on low). Freeze in portions. Serve with mashed potato or soft bread.

- Haem iron, B12, zinc, collagen from connective tissue
- Deeply warming, blood-building, immune-supportive
- Requires no effort to eat — soft, rich, and nourishing

4. Oat and Almond Lactation Porridge

Why: Oats are the most widely used galactagogue food and are also rich in iron, B vitamins, and magnesium. Almonds are a significant source of calcium and healthy fats. Brewer's yeast adds B vitamins. This porridge can be made in 5 minutes and is perfect for 3am when you need something warm and sustaining.

How: Cook 80g rolled oats in 400ml oat or almond milk. Add 1 tbsp almond butter, 1 tbsp brewer's yeast, a teaspoon of cinnamon, and a drizzle of honey or maple syrup. Top with a handful of nuts and seeds. Prepare a batch of overnight oats the night before for a no-cook version.

- Iron, magnesium, B vitamins, calcium, galactagogues
- Blood sugar stabilising, warming, energy-sustaining
- 5 minutes from start to bowl

5. Salmon and Spinach with Mashed Sweet Potato

Why: Salmon is the richest dietary source of DHA (the Omega-3 fatty acid most critical for postnatal mental health). Spinach provides iron and folate. Sweet potato provides complex carbohydrates, potassium, and beta-carotene. This is a complete postpartum meal in under 20 minutes.

How: Bake a salmon fillet (season with lemon and dill, wrap in foil) at 180°C for 15-18 minutes. Steam or wilt a large handful of spinach with a little olive oil and garlic. Mash a sweet potato (microwave for 6-7 minutes, peel, mash with butter and a pinch of nutmeg). Serve together. Too simple to batch cook — just make it twice a week.

- DHA, iron, folate, beta-carotene, Vitamin D
- Directly supports postnatal mental health and blood building
- Easy to prepare, easy to eat, nutrient-dense

Five postpartum teas to keep by the kettle

Warm herbal teas are one of the simplest acts of postpartum nourishment — warming, hydrating, and often medicinally useful. Keep these loose or in bags by the kettle so a cup is always minutes away.

1. Red Raspberry Leaf Tea

Traditionally used throughout pregnancy and highly regarded in the postpartum period. Raspberry leaf is rich in fragarine — a compound that tones uterine muscle — and magnesium, calcium, and iron. In the postpartum period, it supports uterine involution (the uterus returning to its pre-pregnancy size) and may reduce the intensity of afterpains.

Brew: 1-2 tsp dried leaf (or 1 tea bag) in boiling water for 5 minutes. Can be drunk warm or sipped throughout the day.

2. Fennel and Fenugreek Tea

Both fennel and fenugreek are traditional galactagogues with centuries of use across

Middle Eastern, Indian, and Mediterranean cultures. Fennel is also carminative — meaning it reduces bloating and digestive discomfort, which is common in the early postpartum period. Fenugreek contains phytoestrogens that are thought to support prolactin levels.

Brew: 1 tsp fennel seeds and 1 tsp fenugreek seeds, lightly crushed, steeped in boiling water for 10 minutes. Sweeten with honey if desired.

Note: Fenugreek should be avoided in large quantities if you have thyroid conditions. As with all herbal remedies, discuss with your midwife or GP if you have any concerns.

3. Ginger and Turmeric Warming Tea

This tea is an anti-inflammatory powerhouse. Ginger supports circulation, digestion, and nausea (common in the early postpartum period when exhaustion and hormonal change can trigger queasiness). Turmeric contains curcumin — one of the most studied anti-inflammatory compounds in nutrition science. Together, they warm the body from the inside, support liver function, and reduce systemic inflammation.

Brew: Slice 3–4 coins of fresh ginger and add a quarter teaspoon of ground turmeric (or a small piece of fresh turmeric). Steep in boiling water for 8–10 minutes. Add lemon and honey.

4. Oat Straw Tea

Oat straw — the green stem of the oat plant, harvested before the grain forms — is one of the most nourishing nervous system tonics in herbal medicine. It is rich in calcium, magnesium, B vitamins, and silica, and is traditionally used for anxiety, nervous exhaustion, and insomnia. It is safe for breastfeeding mothers and supports the nervous system during a period of intense demand.

Brew: 1 tbsp dried oat straw steeped in boiling water for 15–20 minutes (the longer the steep, the more mineral-rich). Strain and sip throughout the day.

5. Nettle and Dandelion Leaf Tea

Nettles are extraordinarily rich in iron, calcium, Vitamin K, and chlorophyll — arguably the most nutrient-dense herb available to a postpartum mother. Dandelion leaf is a gentle liver tonic and supports hormonal clearance. Together they form a deep green, slightly earthy tea that is particularly useful for blood building in the first two weeks after birth.

Brew: 1 tsp dried nettles and 1 tsp dried dandelion leaf in boiling water for 10 minutes. Add a squeeze of lemon (the Vitamin C supports iron absorption). This can also be made as a cold infusion — steep overnight in cold water for a gentler flavour.

Smoothies — liquid nourishment for the early days

In the first days after birth, appetite is often low and the effort of eating can feel significant. Smoothies offer a way to consume a substantial amount of nutrition quickly, with minimal preparation.

Postpartum Power Smoothie:

- 1 frozen banana (pre-peel and freeze before birth)
- Handful of frozen spinach
- 1 tbsp almond butter
- 1 tbsp ground flaxseeds
- 1 tsp brewer's yeast

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- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- 300ml oat milk or full-fat cow's milk
- Optional: 1 scoop of protein powder, a handful of frozen berries, or a teaspoon of bee pollen

Blend and drink. This smoothie provides iron, Omega-3s, galactagogues, B vitamins, and protein in around three minutes. Prepare the dry ingredients as a batch in advance so it is genuinely effortless to make.

Your freezer stocking plan

Start batch cooking from around 36 weeks. Aim to have 10–14 portions of main meals in the freezer before your due date. Label everything clearly with the date and contents.

Freezer essentials checklist

5–7 portions of bone broth (freeze in 300ml portions)
4 portions of lentil and sweet potato soup
4 portions of slow-cooked stew or casserole
Smoothie ingredients portioned into freezer bags
Oat biscuits or energy balls (bake in batches — freeze well)
Frozen fruit for smoothies
Good quality stock cubes or frozen stock
One tray of lasagne or pasta bake — for the nights when you need something comforting
A loaf of bread or rolls — freeze and toast from frozen

CHAPTER RECAP

- Bone broth is the single most nourishing postpartum food — make it before birth and freeze in portions
- Five key meals: bone broth, lentil and sweet potato soup, slow-cooked stew, lactation porridge, salmon and spinach
- Five key teas: red raspberry leaf (uterine toning), fennel and fenugreek (milk supply), ginger and turmeric (anti-inflammatory), oat straw (nervous system), nettle and dandelion (iron and liver)
- Smoothies provide dense nutrition quickly and effortlessly — prep ingredients in advance
- Start stocking the freezer from 36 weeks. Aim for 10–14 portions before your due date.

📓 **Chapter 4 Meal Planning**

Which of the five meals will you batch cook before your baby arrives? When will you make them?

Which teas will you stock? Write a shopping list now.

Who will make meals for you in the first two weeks? Have you given them specific recipes or ideas from this chapter?

✏️ **YOUR PREPARATION TASK**

Preparation task:

11. Make one batch of bone broth this week and freeze it. Get comfortable with the process before birth.
12. Order or buy the herbal teas in this chapter in advance — they are easy to find online or in health food shops. Have them ready before your due date.
13. Share the freezer meal list with someone who has offered to help and ask them to contribute one meal.
14. Assemble your smoothie bag ingredients and freeze them in pre-portioned bags so they are ready to blend in the first days.

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Chapter 5 — Honouring the Transition: Closing the Bones & Yoni Steaming

This chapter is about two traditional postpartum rituals that are gaining recognition in the West, though both have ancient roots in cultures around the world. They are not medical treatments. They are acts of honour — ceremonies that mark the significance of what you have been through and invite your body and soul to integrate it.

Both are gentle. Both are safe when practised appropriately. And for many women, both are profoundly moving — not because of any single physical effect, but because of what they represent: being seen, being held, and being celebrated for what you have done.

Closing the Bones

Closing the bones is a traditional postpartum ceremony practised in many cultures — most notably in Mexico (where it is called la rebozo or 'closing the bones' after Sobador bodywork), in Morocco, and in parts of Southeast Asia. In essence, it is a warming, wrapping, and holding ceremony designed to help a woman's body and energy gather inward after the opening of birth.

The philosophy

Birth requires a woman to open — physically, energetically, and emotionally. The cervix dilates. The pelvis widens. The pelvic floor stretches. The heart cracks open. This opening is necessary and beautiful. But it also leaves a woman in a state of expansion that, without conscious tending, can feel uncontained.

Closing the bones is, as its name suggests, the counterpart to that opening. It uses warmth, massage, and gentle rhythmic movement — often with a woven cloth called a rebozo — to help the pelvis, hips, abdomen, and body gather inward and feel held.

What happens in a closing the bones ceremony

A closing the bones ceremony is usually offered by a postpartum doula, traditional midwife, or specifically trained bodyworker. It typically takes place between three days and several weeks after birth, and involves:

- A warm bath or foot soak to prepare the body
- Warm oil massage of the abdomen, hips, lower back, and sacrum
- Gentle rebozo work — a skilled practitioner uses a long woven cloth to gently rock, sift, and compress the body from head to toe
- Wrapping — the hips and pelvis are wrapped firmly with the cloth, held, and released — a physical enactment of closing
- Rest in the warmth and silence that follows

Women who have experienced this ceremony often describe it as deeply emotional — many report crying, or feeling a sense of profound relief and completion that they didn't know they needed.

The physical benefits

Beyond the emotional and ceremonial dimension, closing the bones work offers practical physical benefits:

- Rebozo sifting of the abdomen supports uterine involution and releases tension in the abdominal fascia
- Hip compression may help the sacroiliac joints reposition after the widening of birth
- Warm oil massage reduces inflammation, supports lymphatic drainage, and promotes relaxation
- The grounding effect of being physically held and wrapped activates the parasympathetic nervous system

Research note

Formal clinical research on closing the bones is limited, though interest is growing. What the research does clearly support is the benefit of postpartum massage on mood, cortisol levels, and physical recovery. A 2010 review in Expert Review of Obstetrics and Gynaecology found that postpartum massage reduced cortisol, improved sleep quality, and reduced postnatal depression scores. The ceremony is, in essence, a deeply considered postpartum massage held within a meaningful ritual container.

How to access closing the bones

Search for a postpartum doula or traditional bodyworker in your area who is trained in closing the bones or rebozo work. Many doulas now offer this as a standalone postnatal service. The cost varies but is often comparable to a therapeutic massage.

It can also be performed in a simplified form by a trusted partner or friend: a warm bath, warm oil applied to the abdomen and hips, and gentle compression using a long scarf or shawl. The physical technique matters less than the intention of warmth, holding, and care.

Yoni Steaming

Yoni steaming — also called vaginal steaming or chai-yok — is a traditional practice used across Central America, Korea, West Africa, and many other cultures for postpartum recovery and general reproductive health. The word 'yoni' is Sanskrit for the womb and sacred feminine.

In the postpartum context, yoni steaming involves sitting over a bowl of steaming water infused with medicinal herbs. The gentle warmth and herb-infused steam is directed toward the perineum and vaginal opening.

The traditional reasoning

Traditional postpartum medicine recognised that birth leaves the uterus, cervix, and vaginal canal in an open, vulnerable, and physically stressed state. In Korean tradition (the chai-yok ceremony), steaming is performed within days of birth to warm the pelvis, support lochia drainage, and promote healing. In Mayan midwifery, specific herbs are chosen for their properties in toning and cleansing the uterine lining.

What the practice involves

A basic yoni steam involves:

- Bringing 2–3 litres of water to a gentle simmer
- Adding a handful of chosen dried herbs (see below) and steeping for 5 minutes
- Allowing the water to cool slightly — you should feel gentle warmth, never heat

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- Sitting over the steaming water (on a purpose-made yoni steam stool, or by placing the bowl in a toilet with the seat raised) for 15–30 minutes, wrapped in a blanket for warmth
- Resting afterwards

Herbs used in postpartum yoni steaming

- Rosemary — antimicrobial, warming, promotes circulation
- Lavender — calming, antimicrobial, promotes healing
- Calendula — soothing, anti-inflammatory, supports tissue healing
- Mugwort — traditional uterine tonic, promotes cleansing
- Rose petals — soothing and emotionally opening — particularly beautiful for postpartum ceremony
- Chamomile — anti-inflammatory, calming, promotes relaxation

Important safety guidance

Yoni steaming is generally considered safe when practised appropriately. However, the following guidelines are important:

- Do not steam if you have an active infection — discharge that is foul-smelling, unusual in colour, or accompanied by fever. Wait until the infection has resolved.
- Do not steam over broken sutures — wait until perineal wounds are healed, typically 6–8 weeks after birth.
- Never use water that is too hot — it should produce gentle warmth, not heat. Test with your hand first.
- Do not steam if you are still passing heavy lochia — wait until bleeding has reduced significantly (usually after the first 10–14 days for most women).
- Avoid in the first days after birth — allow the body its initial healing first.
- Discuss with your midwife if you have any concerns, particularly if you had a complicated birth, significant tearing, or a caesarean section.

> **A note on evidence**
>
> *Formal clinical research on yoni steaming is limited. Anecdotal reports from midwives and women who practise it describe benefits including reduced postpartum discomfort, improved lochia clearance, and a sense of warmth and wellbeing. The herbs used have individually documented antimicrobial, anti-inflammatory, and soothing properties. The practice should be approached as a gentle, ceremonial form of self-care — not as a medical treatment. Always consult your midwife if you have any questions about suitability for your specific birth and recovery.*

The deeper purpose of both rituals

Whether you choose to explore closing the bones, yoni steaming, neither, or both — the deeper purpose behind both practices is the same: to mark what you have been through.

Birth is not a medical event to be recovered from as quickly as possible. It is a threshold. You were one person before it. You are another person after it. That threshold deserves to be acknowledged, witnessed, and honoured.

These rituals are a way of saying: I see you. I honour what you did. And I am going to take care of the body and the soul that did it.

You deserve that. Every new mother does.

CHAPTER RECAP

- Closing the bones is a traditional postpartum ceremony that uses warmth, oil massage, and rebozo wrapping to help the body gather inward after the opening of birth
- Its physical benefits include supported uterine involution, sacroiliac joint support, lymphatic drainage, and parasympathetic activation
- Yoni steaming is a traditional practice using herb-infused warm steam directed to the perineum — used across multiple cultures for postpartum recovery
- Yoni steaming should not be done over broken sutures, during heavy lochia, or if any infection is present — always check with your midwife first
- Both rituals share the same deeper purpose: honouring the threshold you have crossed and acknowledging the body and soul that crossed it

📓 Chapter 5 Reflection

How do you feel about the idea of closing the bones? Does it feel strange? Appealing? Why?

Is there someone in your life — a partner, a trusted friend, a doula — who could hold a version of this ceremony for you?

What other rituals or acts of ceremony feel meaningful to you? What would help you mark the transition of becoming a mother?

✏️ YOUR PREPARATION TASK

Preparation task:

15. Research postpartum doulas or bodyworkers in your area who offer closing the bones or rebozo work. Make a note of their details even if you don't book yet.
16. Order a selection of dried herbs for yoni steaming in advance — calendula, lavender, rose petals, and chamomile are a gentle and widely available starting blend.

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17. Ask your partner or a trusted person to offer you a simple version of the closing ceremony: a warm bath, warm oil on the abdomen and hips, and gentle wrapping. Tell them what it means to you.

Quick Reference — Your Baby Moon at a Glance

The five insights

Insight	What it means in practice
Retreat	Stay home for at least 2 weeks. Say no without apology. Protect your healing space.
Warmth	Eat warming foods, drink warm teas, stay warm. Replenish blood loss with iron-rich, warming nourishment.
Support	Accept every offer. Ask for specific things. You are not designed to do this alone.
Rest	Sleep when the baby sleeps. Rest when you can't sleep. Protect your rest windows every day.
Ritual	Massage, baths, hair brushing, closing the bones, yoni steaming. Receive care. You matter.

Key nutrients and food sources

Nutrient	Why it matters	Best food sources
Iron	Blood replenishment, energy, milk supply	Red meat, liver, lentils, spinach, pumpkin seeds
Omega-3 (DHA)	Postnatal mental health, brain recovery	Oily fish, walnuts, flaxseeds, DHA supplement
Protein	Tissue repair, wound healing, energy	Eggs, meat, fish, pulses, nuts, Greek yogurt
Calcium + Vit D	Bone health, mood, immune function	Dairy, leafy greens, oily fish, fortified foods, supplement
Zinc	Wound healing, immune function	Meat, shellfish, pumpkin seeds, nuts
Magnesium	Sleep, mood, cortisol regulation	Dark chocolate, almonds, spinach, avocado
B vitamins	Energy, serotonin, red blood cells	Eggs, meat, leafy greens, fortified cereals

The five teas — quick guide

Keep these by the kettle from birth

Red Raspberry Leaf — uterine toning, iron, magnesium. Brew 5 mins.
Fennel & Fenugreek — milk supply, digestive comfort. Brew 10 mins.
Ginger & Turmeric — anti-inflammatory, warming, liver support. Brew 8–10 mins.
Oat Straw — nervous system tonic, calcium, B vitamins. Brew 15–20 mins.

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Nettle & Dandelion — iron-rich, liver tonic, blood building. Brew 10 mins + Vitamin C.

Yoni steaming — safety at a glance

When to wait and when to seek guidance

WAIT if: heavy lochia still present, sutures not healed, active infection, within first 10–14 days

DISCUSS WITH MIDWIFE if: significant tearing, caesarean, complicated birth, or any uncertainty

SAFE when: lochia has lightened, sutures healed, no signs of infection, and you have midwife guidance

ALWAYS: test the temperature with your hand first. Gentle warmth only — never heat.

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"The days after birth matter as much as the days before it. They are not a footnote to pregnancy — they are a chapter all of their own. And they deserve to be lived fully, slowly, and with great tenderness."

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